

Web Watch

The vaporous, but tangible reach of the internet is encompassing every facet of our lives. We take a look at some of these news-making events.

App Watch

This time we show you how to stream to your tablet using Plex and cover some must-have utility tools and apps.

New Directions

With the competition in the mobile space only heating up, companies are looking in new directions to differentiate their products. Join us as we take a look at the biggest game changers this past month

BlackBerry board admits to considering "strategic alternatives"

The admittance of the fact has finally arrived. BlackBerry has announced the formation of a special committee that will "explore strategic alternatives". The company says this is to look at new ways of enhancing brand value, as well as accelerating BlackBerry 10's growth. The Special Committee of the Board is comprised of Barbara Stymiest, Thorsten Heins, Richard Lynch and Bert Nordberg, and will be chaired by Timothy Dattels.

But, the rather telling statement comes in the form of "These alternatives could include, among others, possible joint ventures, strategic partnerships or alliances, a sale of the company or other possible transactions." Quite clearly, the company has, to a certain extent, admitted that it needs to look at the option of selling. However, as expected, BlackBerry is still playing up the product BlackBerry 10, the cross-platform BlackBerry Messenger and the wider deployment of BlackBerry Enterprise offerings.

For this process, BlackBerry has hired J.P. Morgan as its financial advisor. Skadden Arps and Torys LLP will both be the legal advisors. However, the company has specified that this process may still not result in any significant changes. As



The not-so-secret watch from Samsung

per the statement, "There can be no assurance that this exploration process will result in any transaction. The company does not currently intend to disclose further developments with respect to this process, unless and until its Board of Directors approves a specific transaction or otherwise concludes the review of strategic alternatives."

Samsung's secret Galaxy Gear Smartwatch

Rumours about the existence of a smartwatch have been around ever since we saw Dick Tracy use it in the comics and then on the TV show. We've seen a few Android-powered watches hit store shelves, but they failed to impress us. In the past few months, we've heard rumours about Apple and Samsung working hard to launch a smartwatch.

New reports circulating on the internet suggest that Samsung will unveil its Galaxy Gear smartwatch to the world at an

event in Berlin on September 4. Samsung has sent out media invites for the event, and speculations suggest that the Galaxy Note III will also be unveiled at the same event.

The device will reportedly be called Galaxy Gear and be powered by the Android OS. Apps from Samsung's app store, as opposed to apps from Google's Play Store will be better suited for the Galaxy Gear. Besides having a resolution of 320x320 pixels, Wi-Fi, Bluetooth and NFC to allow for bump-to-sync and authenticate, the smartwatch may include a 2MP camera.

According to Bloomberg, "The global watch industry will generate more than \$60 billion in sales this year, and the first companies to sell devices that multi-task could lock customers into their platform, boosting sales of smartphones, tablets and TVs."

Android runs on 8/10 smartphones

A recent study by Strategy Analytics has found that Google's Android is the most commonly used OS with nearly 80% of handsets sold in the second quarter of 2013 (182.7 million handsets) approximately.

According to the firm, nearly 34.6 million Android tablets were sold in Q2 – double the number of iPads (14.6 million) sold in the same period. Neil Mawston of Strategy Analytics cites Android's numerous hardware partners and varying price points as the reasons for its success.

Apple's iPhone sales have dropped to 14% in the second



Restricted profiles on Android

quarter from Q1. However the IDS report adds that Apple's market share can still pick up in the coming year when Apple will release its rumoured "iPhone 5S" and the new iOS.

Microsoft's Windows Phone is doing well and has managed to grab the third spot from